The defence

Can you defend your analysis and recommendation before a decision-making panel?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Presented your recommendation, defended it under questioning and contributed to your pod's synthesis.

- Present your recommendation in six minutes, answer first.
- Defend the evidence, assumptions and feasibility under questioning.
- Concede uncertainty without abandoning the argument.
- Draw lessons across your pod's cases.

Competencies: I4 · I5 · J2

Session plan



5 min	**Panel briefing**
90 min	**Presentations and defence**
12 min	**Pod synthesis slides**
8 min	**Sealed answers returned**
5 min	**Close**

How today works

1. **Five slides, six minutes**

   Recommendation in the first minute. The chair stops you at six minutes.

2. **Six minutes of questions**

   Individual. The panel draws on the red team questions and on your own weak points.

3. **Pod synthesis**

   Each pod presents one shared slide on what its cases reveal together.

4. **The sealed answer**

   Returned at the end of the session, for your reflection.

The panel

1

Decision-maker

Would I act on this? What exactly do you want me to decide?

2

Finance officer

What does it cost, who pays, and what is the evidence on value?

3

Implementing official

Who will do this, with what staff and powers?

4

Citizen representative

Who gains, who pays, and who was left out?

Guest panellists take the first three roles where possible. Participants from other pods take the fourth.

Questions the panel may ask

Domain	Example question
Framing	Why this problem, and why this decision-maker?
Evidence	What evidence contradicts your diagnosis?
Hypotheses	Which rival explanation is strongest, and why did you set it aside?
Appraisal	What would change your recommendation?
Delivery	What would make implementation fail?
Equity	Who loses if you are right?
Measurement	How will we know within six months whether it is working?

The full question bank, organised by competency domain, is in the Capstone Guide.

Answering well under questioning

- **Answer the question asked, cite the evidence, concede what is uncertain, and return to the decision.**

Overstating is the quickest way to lose a panel's trust. Saying the evidence is thinner here, and this is what would settle it, usually gains it.

The pod synthesis slide

1

About the method

Which tool did most work across your four cases, and where did it mislead?

2

About institutions

Where did delivery break in each case? Is there a pattern?

3

About evidence

What kind of evidence was missing in every case, and what would fill the gap?

One slide, presented jointly in three minutes. It carries the 5 per cent pod synthesis mark.

Activity: The final boardroom presentation

Present and defend a recommendation before a decision-making panel, as in professional practice.

Scenario

Each participant presents a five-slide pitch to a panel playing the decision-maker, a finance officer, an implementing official and a citizen representative. Six minutes of presentation are followed by six minutes of questions. Pods then present their synthesis slides.

What to do

1. Present your five slides in six minutes; the chair shows a card at five.
2. Answer the panel's questions for six minutes.
3. Note the question you found hardest.
4. Pods present their synthesis slide in three minutes.
5. Collect your sealed answer at the close.

Time About 12 minutes per participant

Groups Individual presentations, grouped by pod

Output A presentation, a defence and a pod synthesis slide

Opening the sealed answer

- **Open the answer you sealed on Day 3. What changed, what did not, and why?**

Your 500-word reflection is due with the client report, 72 hours from now. Changing your mind in response to evidence is assessed as a strength.

Your case: Worksheet 10.1

Capstone submission

1. Revise your recommendation in response to the panel's questions.
2. Write the client report: 3,500 to 4,500 words, with annexes.
3. Finalise the evidence register and check every citation.
4. Write the 500-word reflection on your sealed answer.
5. Submit everything within 72 hours, with the AI-use disclosure.

Hand in

Client report, final deck, evidence register, reflection and AI disclosure within 72 hours of the end of Day 20.

Quality check

The report answers the decision-maker's question in its first paragraph.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. Lead with the decision you want, and the evidence for it.
2. Concede uncertainty honestly; it builds trust.
3. The same method revealed different things in each case. That is what transfer looks like.
4. You have taken a public problem from a vague concern to a defended recommendation.

Exit task Write down the one skill from this course you will use first in your next piece of work.

Before the next session

Independent work

Write and submit the capstone within 72 hours. Use the panel's questions: the report should answer each of them.

Read

No set reading today.

Submit the capstone within 72 hours. Final feedback follows, together with the comparison of your entry and exit diagnostics.